Michael Lopez

Data Leader · Civic Tech & Social Impact

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Data leader. Six years helping build the Child Poverty Action Lab's data operations from a two-person team to two in-house engineers and a four-person vendor team, leading it through a CDO transition, and shaping the org-wide AI rollout. I make the architecture and build-vs-partner calls myself. I take teams and systems from nothing to running.

EXPERIENCE

Child Poverty Action Lab DALLAS, TX · 2020 – PRESENT

Director, Data Operations Jan 2026 – Present

- Lead CPAL's data platform migration to Databricks (Unity Catalog, Workflows, Lakebase + Lakehouse on AWS, Git-tracked orchestration), systematizing around 40 pipelines from file-based storage onto unified cloud infrastructure
- Manage two in-house data engineers (direct reports) and direct a 4-person vendor data engineering team executing the internal data roadmap
- Built AI-enabled team workflows (Claude Code with custom skills and agents, prompt caching with the Anthropic API), including multi-agent code review with independent verification, accelerating how we develop pipelines, write documentation, review code, and communicate with stakeholders
- Maintain the eviction data workstream across four North Texas counties (~48,000 Dallas filings in 2025), feeding 12+ partners daily including the Dallas Eviction Advocacy Center and the Princeton Eviction Lab

Director, Data May 2023 – Dec 2025

- Helped build CPAL's data operations from a single analyst to a team of 2–4 reporting to me; led hiring for the org's first data engineer and prior analyst roles
- Led the data org through the CDO transition (Dec 2024 to Dec 2025): set department roadmap, hiring, vendor strategy, and budget, reporting directly to the CTO
- Directed CPAL's citywide risk terrain modeling through 2024; division-level findings informed Office of Integrated Public Safety Solutions deployment and drove blight-remediation site selection and neighborhood amenity construction
- Modeled Dallas's rental supply gap for CPAL's annual Rental Housing Needs Assessment (2023–2024): a 33,660-unit shortfall at or below 50% AMI, projected to 83,500 by 2030
- Oversaw a 30+ app R Shiny suite informing decisions across housing, public safety, maternal health, benefits delivery, and criminal justice
- Evaluated and selected the enterprise tooling stack: Databricks (over Snowflake and dbt Cloud, after a capacity assessment) and vendor data feeds (MySidewalk, DataAxle); shaped the org-wide setup and rollout of Claude Enterprise

Manager, Data May 2022 – May 2023

- Ran CPAL's citywide risk terrain modeling on Dallas PD incident data joined to Data Axle property and business records (SIMSI), producing division-level environmental risk surfaces to target place-based violence prevention
- Led development of R Shiny applications, shifting the organization toward interactive data products
- Mentored analytics interns; one was subsequently hired as a full-time analyst

Associate, Data Jun 2020 – Apr 2022

- Created the initial eviction data pipeline in R, laying the groundwork for the system now serving four North Texas counties
- Built the Community Resource Explorer, indexing community-resource access within two miles of every Dallas school campus to find the least-resourced neighborhoods; helped define disbursement of a $1.25B bond package
- Developed dashboards and reports in R, QGIS, Tableau, and ArcGIS for internal teams and community partners

EARLIER LEADERSHIP & POLICY EXPERIENCE

Health and Social Policy Intern, Children at Risk Jun 2019 – Aug 2019

Led policy research on early childhood development and developed policy briefs for senior leadership and state stakeholders.

Research Coordinator, University of Texas at Dallas Aug 2016 – Dec 2018

Managed the Developmental Neurolinguistics Lab; recruited, trained, and supervised 10–15 research assistants each semester and 300+ participants.

SKILLS

Analysis & Languages	R (tidyverse, sf, Shiny) · SQL · Python · TypeScript
Data Platform	Databricks (Lakehouse + Unity Catalog) · PostgreSQL / Neon · DuckDB · Polars · PostGIS · CKAN
Visualization & Geospatial	R Shiny · Tableau · Mapbox GL · Spatial SQL · QGIS · ArcGIS
AI Workflows	Claude Code (custom skills & agents) · Anthropic API · Google Cloud Vision (OCR)
Methods	Risk Terrain Modeling · Index Construction & PCA · Spatial Analysis · Needs Assessment & Supply Modeling
Domains	Housing & Eviction · Public Safety · Criminal Justice · Maternal Health · Benefits Delivery · Community Development

EDUCATION

Master of Public Policy, University of Texas at Dallas

Bachelor of Arts, Psychology & Anthropology, Florida International University

SELECTED PROJECTS

- **Dallas County Eviction Data.** Daily eviction-filing feed reaching 12+ legal-aid and outreach partners; ~48,000 Dallas filings a year turned into tenant outreach.
- **North Texas Evictions** northtexasevictions.org**.** Public-facing eviction data transparency dashboard for North Texas.
- **Parcel Block Walking Tool.** Field-outreach tool flagging homes likely missing a homestead exemption; ~20 active field-team users across outreach partners.
- **DigiLab** digilab.cards**.** Community-sourced tournament data platform for the Digimon and Gundam card game scenes; 10,800+ tournaments and 19,100+ players tracked, built and run solo through agentic workflows.

SELECTED MEDIA

- **The Lab Report:** Data visualizations for Dallas homeless-enforcement and patrol-staffing analyses (2026)
- **D Magazine:** “The Lawyer Who Landlords Don’t Want to See in Court” (2024)
- **KERA News:** “Eviction less likely for Dallas County tenants who get a lawyer” (2024)